
When Can Language Models Join Without Lexical Cues?

Unique-Path Traversal versus End-to-End Accuracy under Path Ambiguity

Pankaj Pandey

Independent researcher, India

mightypp.nits@gmail.com

<https://github.com/pankajnits/oir>

Abstract

We ask whether multi-hop answering over knowledge graphs needs readable predicates, or only equality among identifiers. **Opaque isomorphic reasoning (OIR)** is a measurement protocol: a renaming σ of entities and relations that we verify to be injective on each instance’s finite atom set, with no legend in the prompt. HMAC-SHA256 is one generator of σ , not a cryptographic or privacy primitive.

With the start entity already named in the question, unique-path traversal survives sealed relation strings (OpenAI opaque unique 32/32) and both-opaque unique paths are 32/32 for Composer 2.5, OpenAI `gpt-5.6-sol`, and Grok 4.5. When two same-type routes compete and the prompt supplies no semantic-to-symbol map, the typical response is UNKNOWN rather than the decoy city. That end-to-end rate is packaging-sensitive: named-arm Wiki-H5 (the ARM line and case id name the condition) is OpenAI 6/32 (UNKNOWN 24/32, decoy 2/32); arm-neutral ids and header wording move the same graphs across 10–30/32 (Composer/Grok: Appendix B). On the 26 city-valued items the named-arm cell is 5/26. The matched 2×2 is OpenAI-shaped: Grok named-arm English two-path is already 4/32 (arm-neutral 24/32). OpenAI both-opaque two-path is 1/32. We score the answer node, not an emitted (r_1, r_2) . Seals remove lexical cues; they are not a confidentiality proof.

1 Introduction

The scored Wikidata question is *What city is the headquarters of the company led by Michael Eisner?* English unique-path context walks `works_at` then `headquartered_in` to Burbank; that success may use English predicates, or only equality among identifiers. The two-path decoy is a second `person→company→city` route (`partner_of/located_in`) to Kansas City. Opaque two-path keeps the English question and entity names; those predicates become HMAC tokens (`works_at` $\mapsto$ E334675310f05 on the scored Eisner item). Figure 1 is the OpenAI relation-only 2×2 (English unique 31/32; named-arm opaque two-path 6/32, mostly UNKNOWN; packaging of the same graphs is 10–30/32).

OIR measures whether a model can join after English predicate strings are replaced by keyed opaque tokens. We write a 2-hop as two inferred maps (only the answer node is scored): selection $q \mapsto (r_1, r_2)$ and traversal $(v_0, r_1, r_2, G) \mapsto v_2$. Opacity does not, by itself, block traversal. The question is when the prompt no longer maps query semantics onto one of two sealed relation sequences. Putting the start entity in q as the same atom as in V (**start in q**) separates that question from start-entity identification.

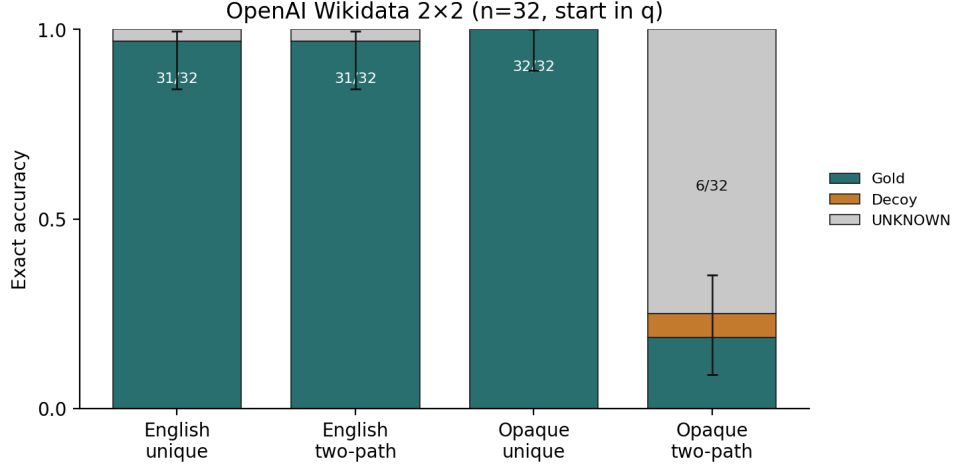


Figure 1: OpenAI WIKI-H5 on Wikidata ($n=32$, start in q ; relation-only). Stacked bars are gold / decoy / UNKNOWN; whiskers are Wilson 95% intervals on exact match. English unique/two-path 31/32; opaque unique 32/32; named-arm opaque two-path 6/32 (mostly UNKNOWN; packaging 10–30/32).

Each instance uses a keyed injective σ on that instance’s atom set (HMAC-SHA256, 48-bit tokens; Section 4). The model emits the answer node in the graph’s namespace or UNKNOWN; recovering σ^{-1} is not scored. A written hop is an execution control. Matched versus novel demonstrations test in-prompt reuse of shown seals.

OIR is a measurement protocol. HMAC renaming is the same family as PrivGemo’s entity map ϕ_Q (Tan et al., 2026); we apply it to relation strings, which that paper leaves as original or clustered schema labels. “Lexical cues” on the primary 2×2 means relation strings (entities stay English); both-opaque is a separate ablation. English multi-hop scores should not be read as evidence that the same join succeeds once predicates are sealed and two same-type routes compete.

This paper reports: (i) unique-route sealed execution with the start in q and no written hop; (ii) when two same-type routes compete without an explicit map, abstention (UNKNOWN) rather than the decoy city, with a packaging-sensitive exact-match rate (Appendix B); (iii) matched demonstrations restore shown seals, while novel seals do not. What is new is the interaction rather than the opacity. Cited privacy KGQA keeps relation strings as readable words (Ning et al., 2026; Tan et al., 2026; Liu et al., 2026). We seal *relation* strings, keep entities English, and cross that with path ambiguity: succeeds on a unique route; underspecified, and packaging-sensitive, when two same-type routes compete (Table 2).

2 Related Work

Think-on-Graph and Reasoning-on-Graphs select the next readable relation (Sun et al., 2024; Luo et al., 2024). Ciphered ICL is not path ambiguity on a labeled graph (Fang et al., 2025; Guo et al., 2026). GSM-Symbolic swaps entity names in English math (Mirzadeh et al., 2025); 2WikiMultihopQA is a readable multi-hop control (Ho et al., 2020).

ARoG anonymizes *entities* while relations stay the retrieval language (Ning et al., 2026). PrivGemo HMAC-seals entities (ϕ_Q , e.g. `ent_17`); relations stay original labels or clustered schema words, not keyed opaque tokens, and a local Hand answers on the raw graph after a remote Brain ranks retrieved paths (CWQ 67% $\rightarrow$ 59%; WebQSP 75%) (Tan et al., 2026). CoR explores readable relations because entities often have no semantics beyond opaque IDs — the OE hide-set, not relation-only WIKI-H5 (Liu et al., 2026). Tang et al. (2023) find LLMs fail when relation names are replaced by symbols (`r1`) and rules must carry deduction; unique-path opaque 32/32 is the complementary case: sealed relations still traverse when topology fixes the route. Guo et al. (2025) report collapse to random guessing among end entities when distractor two-hops have other sources. Wiki-H5 two-

Work	Hidden	Remote task	Join under opacity
ICL	substitution text	ICL task accuracy (bijection inferred)	ICL tasks
CIPHERS			
ARoG	entities; relations readable; topic names in q	retrieve + generate (relations, concepts)	privacy KG-RAG
PrivGemo	entities (HMAC); relations original or clustered schema words	rank retrieved paths; local plaintext answer	privacy KG-RAG
CoR	opaque entity IDs; relations readable	relation-centric exploration	KGQA
OIR	relations (primary 2×2); entities too (ablation); one join or none	emit graph-namespaces answer (no local decode)	selection vs. traversal

Table 1: Related protocols. PrivGemo HMAC-seals entities; relations remain original or clustered schema labels. OIR sends one graph and scores the answer token from the same model.

path, with UNKNOWN allowed, is abstention rather than guessing (OpenAI decoy 2/32, UNKNOWN 24/32); a forced-choice arm is not in this evaluation (Section 7) and would put those protocols on the same scale. OIR withholds retrieved paths on the free arms (Table 1). The primary cell seals relations while entities stay English; both-opaque is a separate ablation.

Chain-of-thought and Text-to-SQL externalize plans over English (Wei et al., 2022; Yu et al., 2018). We ask a behavioral question: can a pretrained model join when the relation vocabulary is freshly randomized and no plan is given? A sealed plan is then an execution upper bound. NLGraph and Talk like a Graph encode graphs without readable typed predicates (Wang et al., 2023; Fatemi et al., 2024); OIR starts from a labeled KG and removes only the relation lexicon. ARM headers are a prompt-surface feature (Sclar et al., 2024). Symbol tuning, binding-ID analyses, and compositional-limit studies change the labels or the task (Wei et al., 2023; Feng and Steinhardt, 2024; Dziri et al., 2023). OIR holds the join, hop length, graph size, and question template fixed and replaces relation strings; unique-path opaque traversal stays at 32/32, so that removal withdraws the cue that would otherwise select between routes rather than blocking execution.

3 Problem Formulation

Let $G = (V, R, T)$ be a labeled multi-relational graph ($T \subseteq V \times R \times V$) and q a natural-language or programmatic query with answer $a \in V$. A **seal** σ is a keyed map from entity and relation strings to opaque tokens that we verify to be injective on the finite normalized atom set of each evaluation instance. We reject any instance where two distinct raw atoms normalize to the same string. Truncated HMAC-SHA256 is not injective over $\{0, 1\}^*$; we use 48-bit truncation because that width is injective on our small per-instance atom sets, not as a cryptographic bound. On the scored Wikidata 2×2 instances, no HMAC collision was observed. HMAC is computed from the normalized atom string; entity and relation types are not domain-separated, so identical plaintext yields the same token regardless of type. On each scored evaluation instance the normalized entity strings and relation strings are disjoint, so no entity is identified with a relation. The model receives G or $\sigma(G)$ and a query form built from σ (or from English, depending on the arm) and must return the answer node in that namespace; recovering σ^{-1} is not scored. Sealing is deterministic *given the instance key*; the same plaintext need not map to the same token across prompts.

A 2-hop join factors as two maps we measure separately:

$$\text{selection: } (q, G, \mathcal{C}) \mapsto (r_1, r_2), \quad (1)$$

$$\text{traversal: } (v_0, r_1, r_2, G) \mapsto v_2. \quad (2)$$

In general, traversal is set-valued ($\tau_G: V \times R \times R \rightarrow 2^V$); we evaluate only instances for which $|\tau_G(v_0, r_1, r_2)| = 1$ for the gold plan (and, on two-path items, for the decoy plan as well), so each scored route has a unique tail. Uniqueness is per plan, not “one answer in G .” We write $q \mapsto (r_1, r_2)$

when G and prompt context $\mathcal{C}$ are held fixed. A sealed join plan supplies (r_1, r_2) and tests (2). Unique-path items with v_0 already in q also test (2) when topology leaves only one route. Free sealed English tests (1) then (2) together. Dual-path items hold G fixed, give two complete routes from v_0 , and vary whether demonstrations expose the gold seals. The CEO free-English arm does *not* put v_0 in q as a single graph atom (the question is hashed piecewise), so it is not a pure test of (1).

A 2-hop is *structurally executable* when (r_1, r_2) is given, or when topology leaves only one 2-hop from a start already in q . The prompt *explicitly maps* query semantics onto one relation sequence when it contains English predicates, a legend, or demonstrated seals. When two complete routes exist and relation tokens are arbitrary HMAC strings with no such mapping supplied, selection is *unsupported by explicit cues* under this construction. Residual statistical structure can remain (token form, order, HMAC vs. permutation rates); we do not claim mathematical unidentifiability. Without an external semantic-to-symbol map, the gold route is not explicitly identifiable from the sealed two-path graph alone; any successful selection must rely on residual statistical cues or information supplied elsewhere in the prompt. Low exact-match is therefore unsurprising when the prompt provides no explicit mapping; it is not evidence that traversal failed. Dual-path separates those cases: in-prompt reuse of demonstrated relation-seal correspondences restores end-to-end accuracy; novel seals receive no such mapping. Models may abstain (UNKNOWN) rather than guess. That is selective prediction (El-Yaniv and Wiener, 2010; Geifman and El-Yaniv, 2017), studied in language models as calibration and abstention (Kadavath et al., 2022; Wen et al., 2025): coverage is the fraction of items with a non-UNKNOWN parse, and selective accuracy is exact match among those items, not a forced-choice among the two routes.

After sealing, the Eisner unique-path CONTEXT is `Michael_Eisner | E334675310f05 | The_Walt_Disney_Company then The_Walt_Disney_Company | Eac04fab538ca | Burbank` (12-hex tokens; entities remain English on the primary 2×2).

We use five measurement arms. **Readable English** is the baseline (start in q ; names and predicates unsealed). **Unique opaque** has one 2-hop and no plan: execution when topology uniquely determines the route. **Two-path opaque** has two same-type 2-hops and no plan: end-to-end behavior when two complete routes compete and the prompt supplies no semantic-to-symbol map; the scored output is the answer node or UNKNOWN, not (r_1, r_2) . **Sealed join plan** writes (r_1, r_2) over σ -atoms (execution control); a non-LLM router saturates on the same sequence. **Free sealed English** seals the question and graph with no plan and no legend. On CEO, the question is hashed piecewise, so the full person atom in G typically does not appear in q (confounded; not the matched factorial). Additional scaffolds (name/key legends, sealed demonstrations) appear as ablations.

The scored output on every free arm is that answer node (plaintext city when entities stay English; $\sigma(a)$ when entities are sealed) or UNKNOWN. We infer whether selection was supported from those end-to-end outcomes and from controls (unique topology, written hop, matched vs. novel seals); we do not score an emitted (r_1, r_2) . Throughout, “selection failure” names that inference about the latent (r_1, r_2) stage; we do not observe the pair.

4 Method

Seal recipe. Normalize each atom: strip; collapse whitespace to `_`; map other non-alphanumeric characters (except underscore, period, hyphen) to `_` using the ASCII class `[A-Za-z0-9_.-]` (so `Zürich` $\rightarrow$ `Z_rich`; pure CJK keeps Unicode); truncate to 64; empty maps to `EMPTY`. The CEO JSON already deleted diacritics upstream. Distinct raw atoms must normalize to distinct strings. Tokens are HMAC-SHA256 over UTF-8 bytes with a per-item 16-byte key; the token is `E` plus the first 6 digest bytes as 12 hex digits. HMAC is keyed renaming, not a security mechanism: 48-bit truncation is instance-wise injective on our small atom sets. On the scored Wikidata 2×2 graphs, normalization and HMAC produced no collisions among prompt atoms. The intervention removes lexical semantics and also changes token-level surface statistics; permutation and alphanumeric generators assess robustness to that latter variation (Table 6). The atom `Michael Eisner` normalizes to `Michael_Eisner`, so those two strings receive the same seal. Hashing the question token-by-token does not reconstruct that graph atom, which is the missing-start failure a name-binding wrapper is designed to prevent. Reported opaque cells are performance under this keyed HMAC construction, not a claim that every opaque identifier distribution yields the same rate.

Matched 2×2 (start in q). The $n=32$ suite is a seeded random sample of 32 of 73 Wikidata-derived CEO records (`random.Random(20260821).sample`; Vrandečić and Krötzsch, 2014), not a published CEO benchmark and not a hand-picked subset. Each instance is 4 triples (unique-path: 6 entities with a disconnected decoy island; two-path: 5 entities sharing the start). The gold two-hop uses `works_at` then the `headquarters` relation; the question says “led by”. The competing two-path route is synthetic (`ambig_edges` attaches record $i+1$ ’s company/HQ under `partner_of/located_in`; not a Wikidata fact; decoy HQ pool = gold HQ pool). To isolate relation selection from start-entity identification we keep the start string in the question and hold hop length, template, and graph size fixed. Two factors vary: relation labels (English vs. HMAC) and topology (one 2-hop from the start vs. two). Tails are intended as the same type; Wikidata P159 was not filtered (buildings/stations/a street among gold HQs; both OpenAI opaque two-path decoys sit on city/non-city pairs; Appendix A). On Wikidata two-path graphs both intermediates are companies (`works_at/headquartered_in` vs. `partner_of/located_in`). In the primary run the gold 2-hop is listed before the decoy 2-hop in CONTEXT; that order is the same in the English and opaque arms. A shuffled listing of the same 32 graphs and HMAC keys (16 gold-first, 16 decoy-first) is a robustness check on a later endpoint snapshot (Appendix A): English two-path 29/32, opaque two-path 5/32 (UNKNOWN 25/32, decoy 1/32). Opaque gold-first is 3/16 vs. decoy-first 2/16: putting the decoy route first does not raise decoy selection.

The primary two-path prompt is a single user message:

```
MODEL UNDER TEST. Read ONLY this file. Use CONTEXT only.
No other files.
Format: ANSWER_PLAIN[...]: <city_or_UNKNOWN>
ARM OPAQUE_AMBIG: opaque relations, English entities;
two 2-hops from start.
```

It does *not* contain the equality-recipe line (Appendix J). The format token is `<city_or_UNKNOWN>`, but six gold HQs are not cities (Appendix A). A model that obeys the format on those items must emit UNKNOWN. The $n=32$ hash-pinned cell remains the primary report; Section 5.1 also scores the 26 city-valued items. English two-path is 31/32 under that CONTEXT-only instruction, so the line does not by itself force abstention. Readable names (Eisner, Burbank) still leave OpenAI at UNKNOWN 24/32 on opaque two-path: either parametric HQ is treated as inadmissible, or the verb does not map onto one seal. We cannot separate those readings here (Section 7). The CEO three-arm decoy 2-hop begins at a different person; it is not the matched two-path factorial.

Further constructions. The relation-only factorial keeps entities English. A second isolation suite on the same 32 CEO records seals entities, relations, or both, always with the start token in q . Opaque-entity / English-relation (OE) is the ARoG-like cell: readable predicates, anonymous nodes. Both-opaque (WIKI-OO) seals entities *and* relations; it is a complementary ablation, not the primary relation-only 2×2. Readable entity names therefore leave residual pretrained world knowledge as a possible cue; both-opaque is not a substitute for synthetic identifiers.

WikiMovies facts are sampled from the public MetaQA movie KB (Miller et al., 2016; Zhang et al., 2018). MOVIE-A32 and MOVIE-A100 leave English verbs such as *directed* in q ; MOVIE-B hashes question atoms except the bracketed start entity. We exclude a genre-vs-language variant because object type would bypass relation selection. This is not an evaluation on the official MetaQA 14K test split. Dual-path holds G fixed with two complete 2-hop routes and varies whether demonstrations expose the gold seals (Appendix D).

Scoring. The format asks for one answer token in the graph’s namespace or UNKNOWN. Primary metric: exact match (UNKNOWN is a miss). Scored UNKNOWN is an explicit UNKNOWN line or a reply from which no answer token was parsed, including empty OpenAI completions. On two-path arms we also report decoy and UNKNOWN rates (Table 3). Wilson 95% intervals use $z=1.96$ (Wilson, 1927) ($0/32 \Rightarrow [0.00, 0.11]$; $6/32 \Rightarrow [0.09, 0.35]$; $32/32 \Rightarrow [0.89, 1.00]$). On the OpenAI Wikidata 2×2, English two-path is correct and opaque two-path is not on 25 of 32 paired items, and the reverse never occurs (McNemar exact two-sided complete-case $p=5.96 \times 10^{-8}$; McNemar, 1947). That is the two-path paired contrast, not an interaction test. That p clears Bonferroni over 60 reported cells ($\alpha/60 \approx 8 \times 10^{-4}$); we do not treat every secondary cell as a confirmatory test. **Isolation** means one quiz per file with gold answers stored outside the model-visible prompt (stricter than multi-quiz

batch files). Isolation $n=32$ uses one quiz per file and a per-item HMAC. Cells marked **n.r.** were not evaluated; we never impute them as zeros. *Mid-hop error* means the model emits the sealed mid-hop company token instead of the headquarters answer.

Models. The primary roster is Composer 2.5, OpenAI `gpt-5.6-sol` (hereafter OpenAI), and Grok 4.5. Secondary packaging probes additionally use an unversioned Claude endpoint (Anthropic model id not stored; Appendix F). `gpt-5.6-sol` is the GPT-5.6 Sol Chat Completions endpoint (Sol is the flagship-equivalent tier of the GPT-5.6 family; <https://developers.openai.com/api/docs/models/gpt-5.6-sol>). OpenAI cells use that API with no tools, a single sample, and temperature omitted because that family rejects temperature 0 (`max_completion_tokens` 512). The runner does not pass `reasoning_effort` and used the unpinned alias `gpt-5.6-sol`. Composer 2.5 and Grok 4.5 ran through Cursor’s agent SDK on the same quiz files, with a reply-only preamble OpenAI never received. Tools, retry, and empty-reply handling are not equated (OpenAI locked empty completions as UNKNOWN). Cross-family two-path gaps may partly reflect harness. The opacity $\times$ ambiguity pattern is most interpretable for OpenAI. Unique both-opaque 32/32 is the three-family traversal cell. Isolation quizzes (`runs/`) and locked exact-match scores (`results/`) are at <https://github.com/pankajmits/oir>. Inference settings are Appendix A.

5 Results

Table 2 names the cells. WIKI-H5 is the primary discovery (OpenAI $n=32$). MOVIE-B is a cross-dataset check, not a resampling of WIKI-H5. Packaging probes are Appendix G.

ID	Dataset	Condition	n	Models	Scored
WIKI-H5	Wikidata CEO	rel-only 2 $\times$ 2, start in q	32	OpenAI	node
WIKI-OO	same graphs	both-opaque	32	3 families	$\sigma(a)$
WIKI-SHUF	same two-path	listing order	32	OpenAI	city
MOVIE-A32	WikiMovies	actor $\rightarrow$ movie $\rightarrow$ dir vs writer	32	3 models	person
MOVIE-A100	WikiMovies	same hops; verbs in q	100	OpenAI	person
MOVIE-B	WikiMovies	same hops; verbs hashed	100	OpenAI	person
DUAL	WikiMovies/synth	matched vs. novel demos	32	3 models	$\sigma(a)$
CEO-NL	Wikidata CEO	piecewise q , no plan	32	3 models	$\sigma(a)$

Table 2: Cell inventory. WIKI-H5 is the OpenAI discovery (Composer/Grok in Table 3). Scored output is the answer node; six P159 golds are not cities (Appendix A). A32/A100/B share the actor $\rightarrow$ movie $\rightarrow$ director vs. writer template; A100 Condition A uses a thinner ARM than A32. Isolation cells use per-item HMAC; batch three-arm $n=12/n=24$ share one key per file.

5.1 Opacity $\times$ path ambiguity

WIKI-H5 holds the start string in q and varies only relation lexicality and the number of 2-hops from that start. OpenAI isolation $n=32$ is the primary cell (Table 3). English unique $\approx$ English two-path $\approx$ opaque unique, while opaque two-path is much lower. A written hop on the ambiguous graph is 32/32 (control). Wilson 95%: 32/32 $\Rightarrow$ [0.89, 1.00], 31/32 $\Rightarrow$ [0.84, 0.99], 6/32 $\Rightarrow$ [0.09, 0.35]. Figure 1 plots the OpenAI 2 $\times$ 2; Table 3 gives all three families.

Let Δ_{opq} be opaque minus English exact-match. Unique path: $\Delta_{\text{opq}} = +1/32$ (32/32 vs. 31/32). Two-path: $\Delta_{\text{opq}} = -25/32$ (6/32 vs. 31/32). The descriptive difference-in-differences is $-26/32$. The primary paired comparison is two-path English versus opaque: 25 items English-correct and opaque-wrong, 0 reverse (McNemar exact two-sided $p=5.96\times 10^{-8}$; McNemar, 1947). Opacity is not a randomized within-item treatment; we report Wilson intervals and these paired counts. The primary p remains significant under Bonferroni over 60 cells; Wilson intervals treat items as independent Bernoulli trials, which the cyclic decoy construction slightly violates (Appendix A). On the 26 city-valued items (six P159 non-city HQs held out) OpenAI unique English, unique opaque, and English two-path are 26/26; opaque two-path is 5/26 (UNKNOWN 21, decoy 0; McNemar 21 vs. 0, $p=9.54\times 10^{-7}$; McNemar, 1947). Unique-path Δ_{opq} is then 0/26: the +1/32 on the full suite is item 3 (NRK_Marienlyst) under the city format token. Composer English two-path 26/32 is

Wikidata cell (iso. $n=32$)	OpenAI	Composer 2.5	Grok 4.5
English, unique	31/0/1/0	29/0/2/1	32/0/0/0
English, two paths	31/0/1/0	26/0/6/0	4/0/28/0
Opaque, unique	32/0/0/0	27/0/3/2	30/0/2/0
Opaque, two paths	6/2/24/0	10/0/22/0	1/0/31/0
Opaque two paths + plan	32/0/0/0	28/0/3/1	32/0/0/0

Table 3: Four-way outcomes: gold / decoy / UNKNOWN / other wrong token. On this table UNKNOWN is an explicit UNKNOWN line (missing/unparsed 0; both-named 0). Composer “other” cells are a wrong city that is neither gold nor decoy (English unique 1, opaque unique 2, plan 1). OpenAI’s two decoys are P159 type-asymmetric pairs. Coverage and selective accuracy for every two-path row are in the surrounding text. Grok already returns UNKNOWN on English two-path.

26/26 on cities (all six misses are non-city). `Lod` is Composer English unique item 31; that item’s two-path reply is UNKNOWN. Grok English two-path is 4/26: that abstention is not a format artifact. An optional sign-flip of the per-item interaction contrast is Appendix I (same numerical p , different test). Opacity alone does not block traversal; the drop is concentrated in the two-path condition.

This pattern is *not* a universal three-family result. Grok English two-path is already 4/32 (UNKNOWN 28): ambiguity without opacity produces abstention for that family. Composer English two-path is 26/32. Opaque unique remains high (Composer 27/32, Grok 30/32); opaque two-path drops (10/32, 1/32); a written hop recovers (28/32, 32/32). Exact-match alone hides the behavior: opaque two-path is mostly UNKNOWN, not decoy. Coverage is the fraction of items with a non-UNKNOWN parse; selective accuracy is exact match among those items (El-Yaniv and Wiener, 2010; Geifman and El-Yaniv, 2017). Two-path coverage / selective accuracy: OpenAI English 31/32, 31/31 and opaque 8/32, 6/8; Composer English 26/32, 26/26 and opaque 10/32, 10/10; Grok English 4/32, 4/4 and opaque 1/32, 1/1. A forced uniform guess among two routes would be 1/2; that is not the relevant null once UNKNOWN is allowed.

On the same graphs under two other opaque generators, unique-path accuracy exceeds two-path accuracy (permutation 31/32 vs. 15/32; alphanumeric 29/32 vs. 12/32; Table 6). Direction agrees across three generators; the two-path *rate* is not invariant.

5.2 Both-opaque and readable relations

Table 4 is a second isolation suite on the same 32 records (ANSWER_SEALED; start seal in q). Unique-path both-opaque is 32/32 for all three families. Composer/Grok relation-only unique (27/32, 30/32 in Table 3) is a different file, not evidence that hiding entities helps. Two-path both-opaque is OpenAI 1/32 (Wilson [0.01, 0.16]), Composer 0/32, Grok 0/32. A written hop recovers (32/32, 28/32, 32/32). OpenAI OE two-path (opaque entities, English relations) is 32/32: readable predicates restore end-to-end accuracy with anonymous nodes under this construction. Grok OE two-path remains 3/32.

WikiMovies unique-path with English verbs in q (MOVIE-A32) is 32/32 for all three families; opaque two-path is 17/32, 17/32, 0/32, with plan 32/32. MOVIE-A32 and MOVIE-A100 are the same actor→movie→director vs. writer template (person tails). A32’s ARM names two 2-hops; A100’s is OPAQUE_AMBIG $n=100$. On the 32 overlapping gold names OpenAI is 17/32 (15 UNKNOWN, decoy 0) vs. 29/32 under A100’s thinner ARM (all 15 UNKNOWNs become gold; three of the original golds also flip). The extra 68 items are 67/68, which is why the $n=100$ cell is 96/100. Keys differ; they cannot explain an English-name lookup. Director is always the first person-tail, so parametric knowledge and a listing-slot heuristic are not separated. Movie-B keeps those names, hashes the verbs, and is 3/100. The contrast is not a same-prompt Wiki-H5 replication; it remains the only header-width comparison we have (Section 7). Verbs in q can cue seals; we do not treat Condition A as a selection result.

5.3 WikiMovies: hashed verbs

Table 5 uses the same actor→movie→director vs. writer template as MOVIE-A32 (person-valued tails). Condition A leaves *directed/starred* in q (not a selection result). Condition B hashes those verbs: OpenAI unique 100/100, two-path 3/100 (UNKNOWN 87, decoy 0, both-named 10; Wilson

Arm	Ent.	Rel.	OpenAI	Composer	Grok
Unique path	opaque	Eng.	32/32	32/32	32/32
Two paths	opaque	Eng.	32/32	28/32	3/32
Unique path	opaque	opaque	32/32	32/32	32/32
Two paths	opaque	opaque	1/32	0/32	0/32
Two paths + plan	opaque	opaque	32/32	28/32	32/32

Table 4: WIKI-OO and OE on the same 32 graphs (start in q). OpenAI OE two-path 32/32; both-opaque two-path 1/32. Plan is a control.

WikiMovies people (OpenAI, $n=100$)	Unique	Two-path
English relations, Condition A (verb in q)	100/100	100/100
Opaque relations, Condition A (verb in q)	100/100	96/100
Opaque relations, Condition B (verbs hashed)	100/100	3/100
Opaque two-path + plan, Condition B	—	100/100

Table 5: MOVIE-A100/MOVIE-B: same actor→movie→director vs. writer template as MOVIE-A32 (Miller et al., 2016; Zhang et al., 2018) (OpenAI $n=100$, start in q). Condition B: unique 100/100, two-path 3/100 (UNKNOWN 87, decoy 0, both-named 10; coverage 13/100, selective accuracy 3/13).

[0.01, 0.08]). Coverage is 13/100 and selective accuracy 3/13. A written hop is 100/100. Composer/Grok Condition A two-path: 62/100, 36/100; Condition B $n=100$ is OpenAI-only. Movie-B’s ARM names two 2-hops (Wiki-H5-style); A100 Condition A does not. The $n=32$ MetaQA-style template cell (Appendix H) is not MOVIE-B.

5.4 In-prompt seal reuse

Sealed demonstrations enable the corresponding joins when the relevant relation seals appear in the demos. Dual-path probes hold G fixed with two complete 2-hop routes (gold vs. decoy) and vary whether those gold seals appeared in the demonstrations. Matched-relation demos expose the gold relation seals; novel-relation demos teach seals that do not appear on the gold route. An explicit join plan is the execution upper bound on the same graphs. “Asymmetric” noise makes the decoy look cleaner; “balanced” noise is symmetric on both mids. Matched-relation is in-prompt reuse of demonstrated correspondences; it is not induction of a general cipher.

Isolation $n=32$ (Figure 2, Appendix D): OpenAI saturates matched-relation under both noise regimes (32/32, decoy 0), scores UNKNOWN on novel-relation balanced (32/32, of which 24 are empty completions), and fails novel-relation asymmetric (0/32; UNKNOWN 24 of which 17 empty, decoy 8). An explicit dual-path plan scores 32/32. The same matched vs. novel contrast on WikiMovies director/writer facts is 32/32 vs. 0/32 for OpenAI, Composer 2.5, and Grok 4.5 (novel is UNKNOWN except Composer decoy 2/32), with plan 32/32. Composer saturates both matched-relation arms and the plan (32/32). Composer isolation-tag novel-relation UNKNOWN is a sealed-demo helper, not a free completion; the free-form lock on those items is decoy 32/32. Grok free-form is UNKNOWN 32/32 on novel-relation asymmetric. Last-demo answer-token copy is 0/32 on every arm.

On a two-path graph a forced uniform guess among the two complete routes is 1/2; that null does not apply once UNKNOWN is a third action. The pattern is consistent with prompt-local reuse of demonstrated seals and provides no evidence of systematic transfer to unseen relation tokens. We do not interpret this as a variable-binding mechanism. Arm definitions: Appendix D.

5.5 Missing-start control

The CEO isolation three-arm is an execution upper bound plus a missing-start cell, not the isolation of selection. Join plans score 32/32 on both plaintext and sealed atoms; SealRouter given the gold sealed relation sequence is 32/32; free sealed English scores 0/32 (all UNKNOWN) for Composer 2.5, OpenAI, and Grok 4.5 (Table 9). Batch $n=12$ and $n=24$ match that pattern. We exclude a batched free-sealed cell that can succeed by returning a unique neighbor without using q .

6 Discussion

A join is structurally executable when the route is unique or (r_1, r_2) is given (unique opaque 32/32; written hop 32/32). The prompt explicitly maps query semantics onto one relation sequence when English predicates, a legend, or demonstrated seals are present. When two complete routes exist and that mapping is absent, selection is unsupported by explicit cues: the prompt presents an underspecified interface, and the typical response is UNKNOWN rather than decoy (Table 3). We do not claim the task is mathematically unidentifiable.

For OpenAI on WIKI-H5, the difference-in-differences is $-26/32$ (25 vs. 0 paired counts). Grok named-arm English two-path is 4/32 (arm-neutral 24/32; Appendix B). English relations restore OpenAI end-to-end accuracy with anonymous entities (32/32); Grok still abstains (3/32). Dual-path shows in-prompt reuse of demonstrated relation-seal correspondences and that novel seals do not transfer. The CEO piecewise-hash 0/32 is an input-binding control, not part of the matched factorial. Unique topology with the start in q , English predicates, matched demonstrations, or a same- σ equality recipe restore execution; a bare schema list does not (Table 11). A written hop saturates, as does a non-LLM router: that is a control. A high English two-path rate does not imply that the same model can join once relation strings are opaque. Under two same-type routes the named-arm Wiki-H5 rate is packaging-sensitive (OpenAI 10–30/32); the typical locked named-arm response is UNKNOWN, not a random decoy. OIR diagnoses residual join ability after readable relations and retrieved paths are withheld. PrivGemo keeps those paths and answers locally (Tan et al., 2026). The two protocols are not interchangeable.

7 Limitations

WIKI-H5 is OpenAI-shaped: Grok named-arm English two-path is already 4/32 (arm-neutral 24/32). The format token `<city_or_UNKNOWN>` makes six P159 golds ill-posed; the 26 city items keep 26/26 vs. 5/26. The suite is $n=32$ of 73 records, one template, one seed; decoys are cyclic, so Wilson intervals are slightly optimistic (McNemar is not). English entities leave parametric cues; HMAC two-path rates vary by generator (6/32, 15/32, 12/32); short pronounceable symbols are not run. Selection is inferred from the answer node. Composer/Grok used a different harness than OpenAI (Appendix A). Selective accuracy on opaque two-path stays high (6/8, 10/10, 1/1): the effect is coverage, not a proof that the join is impossible. ARM and case-id packaging move OpenAI across 10–30/32 (MOVIE-A32 vs. MOVIE-A100: 17/32 vs. 29/32). Forced-choice, scored (r_1, r_2) , and an HQ-city swap are not in this evaluation. MOVIE-B is OpenAI-only.

Ethical considerations

Instances use public Wikidata CEO records (CC0; Vrandečić and Krötzsch, 2014) and the MetaQA/WikiMovies movie graph as publicly released with WikiMovies (Miller et al., 2016) and MetaQA (Zhang et al., 2018). Appendix cells additionally use 2WikiMultihopQA (Apache-2.0; Ho et al., 2020) and Spider (CC-BY-SA-4.0; Yu et al., 2018). No personally sensitive information is used. Model generations are not released as a corpus. Isolation quizzes (`runs/`) and exact-match scores (`results/`) are at <https://github.com/pankajjnits/oir>. OIR is a diagnostic, not a deployed anonymizer: treating HMAC seals as a confidentiality mechanism would over-trust prompts that still contain English names on the primary 2×2 . The intended use is to test whether a claimed join survives sealed relation strings.

8 Conclusion

Unique-route sealed execution succeeds with the start in q (opaque unique OpenAI 32/32; both-opaque unique 32/32 on three families). When two same-type routes compete without an explicit map, models typically return UNKNOWN rather than the decoy. The named-arm Wiki-H5 lock is OpenAI 6/32; header and case-id packaging move the same graphs across 10–30/32, so that cell is not a constant of opacity. Both-opaque two-path is 1/32. That is an underspecified interface, not a scored (r_1, r_2) and not a proof that traversal failed. English predicates, an equality recipe, or matched demonstrations restore end-to-end accuracy. The 2×2 is OpenAI-shaped: Grok named-arm English two-path is already 4/32.

References

- Zhiyu Chen, Wenhui Chen, Charese Smiley, Sameena Shah, Iana Borova, Dylan Langdon, Reema Moussa, Matt Beane, Ting-Hao Huang, Bryan Routledge, and William Yang Wang. FinQA: A Dataset of Numerical Reasoning over Financial Data. *EMNLP*, 2021.
- Nouha Dziri, Ximing Lu, Melanie Sclar, Xiang Lorraine Li, Liwei Jiang, Bill Yuchen Lin, Peter West, Chandra Bhagavatula, Ronan Le Bras, Jena D. Hwang, Soumya Sanyal, Sean Welleck, Xiang Ren, Allyson Ettinger, Zaid Harchaoui, and Yejin Choi. Faith and Fate: Limits of Transformers on Compositionality. *NeurIPS*, 2023.
- Ran El-Yaniv and Yair Wiener. On the Foundations of Noise-free Selective Classification. *JMLR*, 11:1605–1641, 2010.
- Zhouxiang Fang, Aayush Mishra, Muhan Gao, Anqi Liu, and Daniel Khashabi. ICL CIPHERS: Quantifying “Learning” in In-Context Learning via Substitution Ciphers. *EMNLP*, 2025.
- Bahare Fatemi, Jonathan Halcrow, and Bryan Perozzi. Talk like a Graph: Encoding Graphs for Large Language Models. *ICLR*, 2024.
- Jiahai Feng and Jacob Steinhardt. How do Language Models Bind Entities in Context? *ICLR*, 2024.
- Yonatan Geifman and Ran El-Yaniv. Selective Classification for Deep Neural Networks. *NeurIPS*, 2017.
- Shiyuan Guo, Henry Sleight, and Fabien Roger. All Code, No Thought: Current Language Models Struggle to Reason in Ciphered Language. *ICLR*, 2026.
- Tianyu Guo, Hanlin Zhu, Ruiqi Zhang, Jiantao Jiao, Song Mei, Michael I. Jordan, and Stuart Russell. How Do LLMs Perform Two-Hop Reasoning in Context? *arXiv:2502.13913*, 2025.
- Xanh Ho, Anh-Khoa Duong Nguyen, Saku Sugawara, and Akiko Aizawa. Constructing A Multi-hop QA Dataset for Comprehensive Evaluation of Reasoning Steps (2WikiMultihopQA). *COLING*, 2020.
- Saurav Kadavath, Tom Conerly, Amanda Askell, Tom Henighan, Dawn Drain, Ethan Perez, Nicholas Schiefer, Zac Hatfield-Dodds, Nova DasSarma, Eli Tran-Johnson, Scott Johnston, Sheer El-Showk, Andy Jones, Nelson Elhage, Tristan Hume, Anna Chen, Yuntao Bai, Sam Bowman, Stanislav Fort, Deep Ganguli, Danny Hernandez, Josh Jacobson, Jackson Kernion, Shauna Kravec, Liane Lovitt, Kamal Ndousse, Catherine Olsson, Sam Ringer, Dario Amodei, Tom Brown, Jack Clark, Nicholas Joseph, Ben Mann, Sam McCandlish, Chris Olah, and Jared Kaplan. Language Models (Mostly) Know What They Know. *arXiv:2207.05221*, 2022.
- Chenhui Liu, Jianpeng Zhou, and Jiahai Wang. Chain-of-Relations: Faithful and Efficient LLM Reasoning over Knowledge Graphs via Relation-Centric Exploration. *Findings of ACL*, 2026. <https://aclanthology.org/2026.findings-acl.2138/>.
- Linhao Luo, Yuan-Fang Li, Gholamreza Haffari, and Shirui Pan. Reasoning on Graphs: Faithful and Interpretable Large Language Model Reasoning. *ICLR*, 2024.
- Quinn McNemar. Note on the Sampling Error of the Difference Between Correlated Proportions or Percentages. *Psychometrika*, 12(2):153–157, 1947.
- Alexander Miller, Adam Fisch, Jesse Dodge, Amir-Hossein Karimi, Antoine Bordes, and Jason Weston. Key-Value Memory Networks for Directly Reading Documents (WikiMovies). *EMNLP*, 2016.
- Iman Mirzadeh, Keivan Alizadeh, Hooman Shahrokhi, Oncel Tuzel, Samy Bengio, and Mehrdad Farajtabar. GSM-Symbolic: Understanding the Limitations of Mathematical Reasoning in Large Language Models. *ICLR*, 2025.
- Yunfeng Ning, Mayi Xu, Jintao Wen, Qiankun Pi, Yuanyuan Zhu, Ming Zhong, Jiawei Jiang, and Tiejun Qian. Privacy-protected Retrieval-Augmented Generation for Knowledge Graph Question Answering (ARoG). *AAAI*, 2026.

- Panupong Pasupat and Percy Liang. Compositional Semantic Parsing on Semi-Structured Tables. *ACL*, 2015.
- Melanie Sclar, Yejin Choi, Yulia Tsvetkov, and Alane Suhr. Quantifying Language Models’ Sensitivity to Spurious Features in Prompt Design. *ICLR*, 2024.
- Jiashuo Sun, Chengjin Xu, Luminyuan Tang, Saizhuo Wang, Chen Lin, Yeyun Gong, Lionel Ni, Heung-Yeung Shum, and Jian Guo. Think-on-Graph: Deep and Responsible Reasoning of Large Language Model on Knowledge Graph. *ICLR*, 2024.
- Xingyu Tan, Xiaoyang Wang, Qing Liu, Xiwei Xu, Xin Yuan, Liming Zhu, and Wenjie Zhang. PrivGemo: Privacy-Preserving Dual-Tower Graph Retrieval for Empowering LLM Reasoning with Memory Augmentation. arXiv:2601.08739, 2026.
- Xiaojuan Tang, Zilong Zheng, Jiaqi Li, Fanxu Meng, Song-Chun Zhu, Yitao Liang, and Muhan Zhang. Large Language Models are In-Context Semantic Reasoners rather than Symbolic Reasoners. arXiv:2305.14825, 2023.
- Denny Vrandečić and Markus Krötzsch. Wikidata: A Free Collaborative Knowledgebase. *CACM*, 2014.
- Heng Wang, Shangbin Feng, Tianxing He, Zhaoxuan Tan, Xiaochuang Han, and Yulia Tsvetkov. Can Language Models Solve Graph Problems in Natural Language? *NeurIPS*, 2023.
- Jason Wei, Xuezhi Wang, Dale Schuurmans, Maarten Bosma, Brian Ichter, Fei Xia, Ed H. Chi, Quoc V. Le, and Denny Zhou. Chain-of-Thought Prompting Elicits Reasoning in Large Language Models. *NeurIPS*, 2022.
- Jerry Wei, Le Hou, Andrew Lampinen, Xiangning Chen, Da Huang, Yi Tay, Xinyun Chen, Yifeng Lu, Denny Zhou, Tengyu Ma, and Quoc Le. Symbol tuning improves in-context learning in language models. *EMNLP*, 2023.
- Bingbing Wen, Jihan Yao, Shangbin Feng, Chenjun Xu, Yulia Tsvetkov, Bill Howe, and Lucy Lu Wang. Know Your Limits: A Survey of Abstention in Large Language Models. *TACL*, 13:529–556, 2025.
- Edwin B. Wilson. Probable Inference, the Law of Succession, and Statistical Inference. *JASA*, 22(158):209–212, 1927.
- Tao Yu, Rui Zhang, Kai Yang, Michihiro Yasunaga, Dongxu Wang, Zifan Li, James Ma, Irene Li, Qingning Yao, Shanelle Roman, Zilin Zhang, and Dragomir Radev. Spider: A Large-Scale Human-Labeled Dataset for Complex and Cross-Domain Semantic Parsing and Text-to-SQL. *EMNLP*, 2018.
- Yuyu Zhang, Hanjun Dai, Zornitsa Kozareva, Alexander J. Smola, and Le Song. Variational Reasoning for Question Answering with Knowledge Graph. *AAAI*, 2018.

A Protocol, scoring, and models

Isolation quizzes (runs/) and locked scores (results/) are at <https://github.com/pankajmits/oir/releases/tag/v1.0.1> (Python $\geq$ 3.10). OpenAI cells: gpt-5.6-sol, no tools, one sample, August 2026 snapshot, temperature omitted, max_completion_tokens 512; reasoning_effort was omitted, and the runner stores the parsed answer, not the API model string or usage (including reasoning-token counts). WIKI-SHUF is a 7 September 2026 snapshot on the same 32 keys. Composer 2.5 and Grok 4.5 used the same quiz files through Cursor’s agent SDK with a reply-only preamble OpenAI never received; settings are not equated. Composer Wiki-OO unique/two-path, Composer/Grok CEO, Dual *ff and some Dual isolation-tag arms are answer-line locks (cite *ff; Grok Wiki-OO is a one-line tail). A later Composer Wiki-OO unique transcript rerun (composer25tx) is 32/32; two-path stays 0/32 (one decoy vs. lock UNKNOWN 32). Some Dual and no-hop OpenAI cells store empty completions as UNKNOWN; Wiki-H5/Wiki-OO do not. WIKI-H5 uses seed 20260821

and a per-item 16-byte key derived from `oir-fact-2x2-iso-v1` and the item index. The 32 records are `random.Random(20260821).sample` from the 73-row CEO file; two-path decoys attach record $i+1 \bmod 32$, so each item’s decoy company/HQ is the next item’s gold. Wilson intervals in the body treat items as i.i.d.; that is slightly optimistic under this cycle. A SHA-256 lockfile over git-tracked JSON summaries and per-item reply files in `results/` is `results/SHA256SUMS` (regenerate with `harness/write_sha256sums.py`; ignored packs such as `longctx_lm*` are omitted). That file is a hash pin, not a timestamped pre-registration. Verify with `shasum -c results/SHA256SUMS`. Cite GitHub release tag `v1.0.1` rather than branch HEAD. No models were trained. OpenAI cells used Chat Completions on CPU-side API calls (`max_completion_tokens` 512; `header×decoy` 4096). WIKI-H5 isolation is 32 items $\times$ five named arms; `header×decoy` is 224 queries per family. Composer 2.5 and Grok 4.5 used Cursor’s hosted agent API on the same quiz files. Wall-clock is API latency, not local GPU-hours. WIKI-OO is a second suite on those records (`oir-entrel-2x2-iso-v1` and index). MOVIE-A32/MOVIE-A100/MOVIE-B and Dual isolation items are per-item keys; Dual demonstrations reuse that item’s key. CEO-NL isolation $n=32$ uses seed 20260820 and per-item keys. The $n=12$ three-arm is **batch** with one shared key (`oir-ceiling-three-arm-v1`, seed 20260728) for Composer 2.5, OpenAI, and Grok 4.5; $n=24$ is the same protocol at a larger n . We never impute n.r. as zeros.

P159 gold HQs that are not cities: `Broadway`, `NRK_Marienlyst`, `Fox_Plaza`, `CNN_Center`, `Lod_Railway_Station`; `New_Jersey` is a state. OpenAI opaque two-path decoys are items 27 and 31 (`CNN_Center` vs. `Swindon`; `Lod_Railway_Station` vs. `Burbank`). Both decoys are on the non-city subset; city-valued OpenAI opaque two-path is gold 5/26, decoy 0, UNKNOWN 21. Every non-two-path miss in Table 3 for all three families falls on those six golds. Source slice: `Kansas_City` 10/73, `Burbank` 6/73; Disney three times in the 32. An archived Movie-B ARM banner naming director vs. writer is OpenAI two-path 25/100; the locked topology-only Condition B header is 3/100.

The CEO three-arm graphs add extra edges on the gold company (owned-by, partner-of, meta-of). One question template is used. Free English hashes the question piecewise, so the full person atom typically does not appear in q .

B Generator robustness

Opaque generator (OpenAI, start in q)	Unique	Two-path
Keyed HMAC (E+12hex)	32/32	6/32
Random permutation (E+12hex)	31/32	15/32
Random alphanumeric (not HMAC-shaped)	29/32	12/32

Table 6: Generator robustness on the same 32 Wikidata graphs and question template. Unique-path accuracy exceeds two-path accuracy under three independently generated opaque relation maps; the two-path *rate* is not invariant. Wilson: 29/32 $\Rightarrow$ [0.76, 0.97], 12/32 $\Rightarrow$ [0.23, 0.55], 15/32 $\Rightarrow$ [0.31, 0.64]. Alphanumeric two-path is all abstention or gold (decoy 0).

A random permutation of relation labels (HMAC-shaped tokens, not keyed HMAC) on the same Wiki-data 2 $\times$ 2 preserves unique-path accuracy exceeding two-path accuracy: OpenAI 31/32 vs. 15/32 (plan 30/32); Composer 28/32 vs. 2/32 (plan 28/32); Grok 31/32 vs. 0/32 (plan 32/32).

An English-entity ambiguity sweep $k=1..5$ still seals relations (HMAC key `oir-ambig-curve-iso-v1`) and, for every item, reuses one constant decoy route (Cogent Communications $\rightarrow$ Washington, DC). OpenAI stays high (29/32, 29/32, 28/32, 27/32, 28/32; plan 32/32); Composer declines (27/32 to 11/32; plan 29/32); Grok is 29/32 at $k=1$ then 0/32 for $k\geq 2$ (plan 32/32). K2 on the ambig-curve suite (curve HMAC key, constant decoy, named K2 header) is OpenAI 29/32 vs. Wiki-H5 6/32; that is not the `header×decoy` K2 cells (30/32 cyclic, 26/32 constant). Names such as Disney remain, so k is not isolated from entity semantics; neither curve is a replication of both-opaque 1/32. `Header×decoy`, arm-neutral ids, same 32 people (`header_decoy_ablation_iso_*.json`). OpenAI 11 September 2026, 4096 tokens, medium effort, 224/224 stop: H5 20/10, K2 30/26, no ARM 25/27, English 29. Composer and Grok same day, Cursor SDK, `--preamble none`, 224/224 finished: H5 6/2 and 0/0; K2

20/13 and 0/0; no ARM 21/18 and 6/1; English 26 and 24 (markdown wrappers on four Composer answers stripped at score time). Named-arm OpenAI snapshot 5/32 (512 tokens, one NO_OUTPUT) vs. H5 cyclic at the same budget 20/32 (shared CONTEXT/ARM; $F22$ vs. HDA). Constant decoy does not raise the Wiki-H5-header cell on any family.

C Hypothesis status and maps

Arm	Input to the model	Maps tested	Score
English, unique path	readable q , start in q	(1)+(2) (e2e)	31/32
English, two paths	readable q , start in q	(1)+(2) (e2e)	31/32
Opaque, unique path	start in q ; one route; no plan	(2) (e2e)	32/32
Opaque, two paths	start in q ; two routes; no explicit map	e2e; (1) unobserved	6/32
Plan (control)	opaque q plus (r_1, r_2)	(2)	32/32
Binding fail	piecewise q ; start typically absent	start ID (confounded)	0/32

Table 7: WIKI-H5 maps (OpenAI unless noted). Exact match on the answer node, not (r_1, r_2) . Last row is CEO-NL.

Hypothesis	Test	Status
H1. Opacity alone blocks traversal	unique-path, start in q	not supported under this construction (32/32)
H2. Written hop restores e2e (control)	two-path + plan; SealRouter	control (32/32)
H3. Input-binding control (CEO piecewise q)	CEO isolation NL	control (0/32); not selection
H4. Matched demos restore shown seals	dual-path matched vs. novel	supported (32/32 vs. 0/32)
H5. End-to-end accuracy degrades when opaque relations meet path ambiguity	matched 2×2 , start in q	named-arm 25 vs. 0; App. B
H6. Movie KB, hashed verbs (check)	WikiMovies Cond. B $n=100$	OpenAI two-path 3/100
H7. English relations can suffice with opaque entities	Wikidata OE vs. OO	supported for OpenAI under this construction

Table 8: Hypothesis status. H5 is WIKI-H5 (OpenAI). H6 is MOVIE-B. H7 is OpenAI-specific (OE vs. WIKI-OO).

CEO-NL isolation $n=32$	Composer 2.5	OpenAI	Grok 4.5
Sealed plan / SealRouter	32/32	32/32	32/32
Free sealed English (piecewise q)	0/32	0/32	0/32

Table 9: Missing-start control, not WIKI-H5. Batch $n=12/n=24$ and packaging rows: Appendix G.

Cell (iso. $n=32$)	OpenAI	Composer 2.5	Grok 4.5
MOVIE-A32 opaque unique	32/32	32/32	32/32
MOVIE-A32 opaque two-path	17/32	17/32	0/32
MOVIE-A32 two-path + plan	32/32	32/32	32/32
Both-opaque unique	32/32	32/32	32/32
Both-opaque two-path	1/32	0/32	0/32
Both-opaque two-path + plan	32/32	28/32	32/32

Table 10: Three-family isolation beyond Table 3. MOVIE-A32 leaves verbs in q (not a selection result). Both-opaque is Table 4 compactly.

D Dual-path arms

We name the arms by what the demos teach. **Matched-relation** (asymmetric or balanced noise): demos expose the gold relation seals; the decoy path uses different seals. **Novel-relation** (asymmetric or balanced noise): demos teach seals that do not appear on the gold route; both routes are novel at quiz time. **Explicit join plan**: gold relation sequence is written in the prompt.

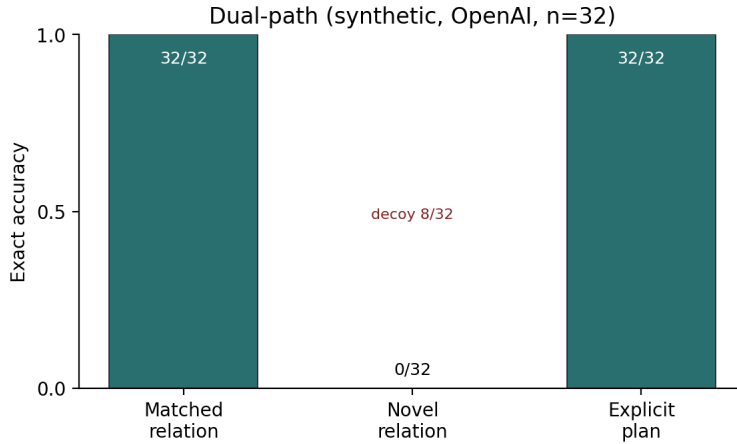


Figure 2: DUAL (synthetic, OpenAI $n=32$): matched 32/32; novel 0/32 (asymmetric decoy 8); explicit plan 32/32.

An $n=8$ cell is zero demos 2/8; one or more demos 8/8. Isolation $n=32$ is the reported dual-path measurement. Local mistral/qwen35 runs are not in the roster (matched-asymmetric 0/32; Qwen matched-balanced 7/32; plan n.r.). Composer isolation-tag novel-relation UNKNOWN is `adv_induction_n32_iso_composer25.json` (helper `run_induce_mut_n32_iso.py`); the free-form lock is `composer25ff` (decoy 32/32). Grok free-form is `grok45ff`.

E No-hop binding (JSON)

Arm (no written hop)	OpenAI	Composer 2.5	Grok 4.5
Schema list only	0/32	0/32	0/32
English protocol (no hop)	32/32	32/32	32/32
Same σ , silent	6/32	19/32	31/32
Same σ + equality recipe	32/32	32/32	32/32
JSONKEY: match broken	0/32	0/32	0/32
Sealed Q, two routes, recipe	31/32	25/32	32/32
Sealed Q, two routes, vague hints	13/32	23/32*	31/32

Table 11: Selection support without a written hop (Wikidata CEO JSON; city or mentor country is the distractor; isolation; per-item HMAC). Schema-only and broken token overlap fail for all three. An English protocol or an equality recipe that does not name the field saturates. Silent same- σ overlap and vague hints are family-dependent, not a three-family restore. OpenAI silent 6/32 and vague-hint 13/32 include 24 and 15 empty completions stored as UNKNOWN. *Composer vague-hint distractor 1/32. JOIN was not evaluated at $n=32$. Wilson: 32/32 $\Rightarrow$ [0.89, 1.00], 0/32 $\Rightarrow$ [0.00, 0.11], 6/32 $\Rightarrow$ [0.09, 0.35], 31/32 $\Rightarrow$ [0.84, 0.99]. Silent same- σ OpenAI 6/32 is a JSON-binding cell, distinct from WIKI-H5. NS_SILENT ARM lines say “Match impossible”; those 0/32 rows are not a sealed-join collapse.

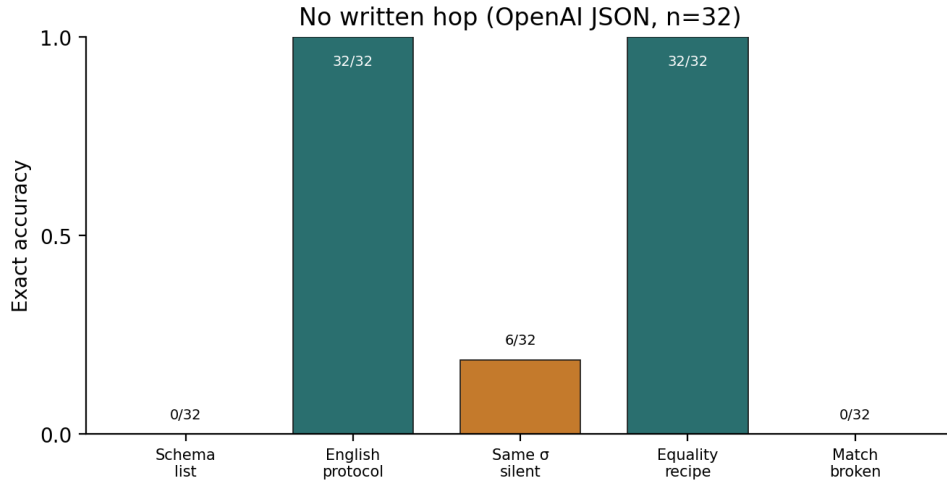


Figure 3: No-hop binding (Wikidata JSON, OpenAI $n=32$).

Figure 3 is the OpenAI row of Table 11. The Table 11 prompts are fixed English blocks (same wording for all three families). We use *equality* rather than similarity: exact identity of sealed tokens, not a continuous metric. Schema list only is a bilingual KEY_SCHEMA (English name = sealed JSON key) plus “Use the schema to read CONTEXT. No JOIN is given.” The English protocol adds that QUESTION and CONTEXT are encoded, that identical tokens are the same entity or field (equality, not decryption), and that schema names plus token equality walk CONTEXT; it also names the asked field as country rather than city. The same- σ equality recipe (Appendix J) does not name country or city in English. It is not the WIKI-H5 prompt. The suite uses the same 32 Wikidata people (per-item keys; seed 20260826–20260829). The OpenAI $n=6$ cell with an English question template and English JSON keys (1/6) is not plaintext Wiki-H5: the start token and all values are sealed, city is a nested distractor under hq, and the prompt forbids world knowledge and allows UNKNOWN. English keys alone do not restore the walk.

F Sealing middleware

The necessary step is binding a typed full name to one graph atom: spaced tokens otherwise miss V . The layer then seals entities, relations, and sensitive values. When the relation sequence is already specified, the join can be executed by a deterministic non-LLM router. If the hop is not compiled, the layer may attach one sealed join as an execution control (not a list of candidate paths). The model,

when used, returns $\sigma(a)$; the layer unseals. Isolation on the CEO vault without start-entity binding is 0/6 vs. full layer 6/6 for Composer 2.5, OpenAI, and an unversioned Claude endpoint (Anthropic model id not stored; plaintext names in the packed prompt: 0). On complex 3-hop and real 2Wiki, Composer 2.5 without binding is 0/6 vs. layer 6/6; OpenAI layer 6/6 (without binding: complex 4/6, 2Wiki 0/6). Those isolation files also attach a join: that is the execution control, not the reason to call a model. The model never receives a retrieved path list and never answers in plaintext (Table 1). The 6/6 scores are this binding-and-join control, not the free WIKI-H5 6/32 cell.

G Packaging probes

These cells test serialization and application packaging, not the matched 2×2 . Sample sizes are $n=6-16$ except a counterfactual 2Wiki sanity check and the public Spider identifier-in- q cell ($n=100$).

Tables / JSON / SQL. Same CEO join as markdown tables, nested JSON, or a value store: free sealed English 0/12, join plan 12/12 (Composer 2.5 and OpenAI both 12/12). JSON keys without a legend: 0/6; a key legend yields 6/6 for OpenAI only (6/6 vs. 0/6); a join plan yields 6/6 for both. Token overlap vs. SQLCOL: break on public Spider is Table 12 (OpenAI; identifier-in- q slice $n=100$: 51/100 vs. 0/100). Specified schema $\rightarrow$ model SQL $\rightarrow$ local execution on the CEO sqlite skin is 6/6, a different cell.

Excel. The NL arm seals a template that already names both join predicates and the person (batched $n=16$). Composer exact-match 0/16 (mid-hop company-token error 16/16) vs. plan 16/16; OpenAI 16/16 on both. Softer than CEO free sealed English.

FinQA / WTQ (Chen et al., 2021; Pasupat and Liang, 2015). Shared sealed context from 414 tables: FinQA NL 0/8 vs. gold programs 8/8; WTQ NL 0/6 vs. LOOKUP DSL 6/6 (Composer). OpenAI matches FinQA and WTQ DSL; WTQ NL is 1/6. Some programs embed literals or gold cell addresses. Not a leaderboard.

Counterfactual 2Wiki sanity check. Composer 2.5 plain NL 200/200 (Wikipedia leak 0); OpenAI batched 150/200 with overlap leak 50/200. We do not treat this as a standard 2Wiki evaluation. Spider: sealed-cell NL 4/12; model SQL executed locally 29/32; gold-SQL engine 191/200 (Appendix K).

English q	Find the number of papers published by the institution “University of Pennsylvania”.
Sealed q (A)	Find the number of E41f626311a9f published by the institution “University of Pennsylvania”.
EQ	q token equals sqlite identifier $\rightarrow$ execute; first-cell gold on this item
NS	same q ; identifiers are HMAC(SQLCOL:name) $\rightarrow$ UNKNOWN
A (name in q)	$n=100$ (45 DBs). EQ 51/100; NS 0/100 (UNKNOWN 100/100)
B (no name in q)	$n=26$. EQ 18/26; NS 20/26 (English q ; legend can still bind)

Table 12: Spider identifier overlap vs. namespace break (OpenAI; Yu et al., 2018). Slice A $n=100$: EQ 51/100, NS 0/100. Not official exact-match. n.r. for Composer/Grok.

Long context / rename. At $\sim 128k$ and $\sim 1.14M$ sealed tokens, free sealed NL remains 0/8; plans 8/8. Paired σ/σ' sealed plans: 12/12 with differing golds (Figure 4).

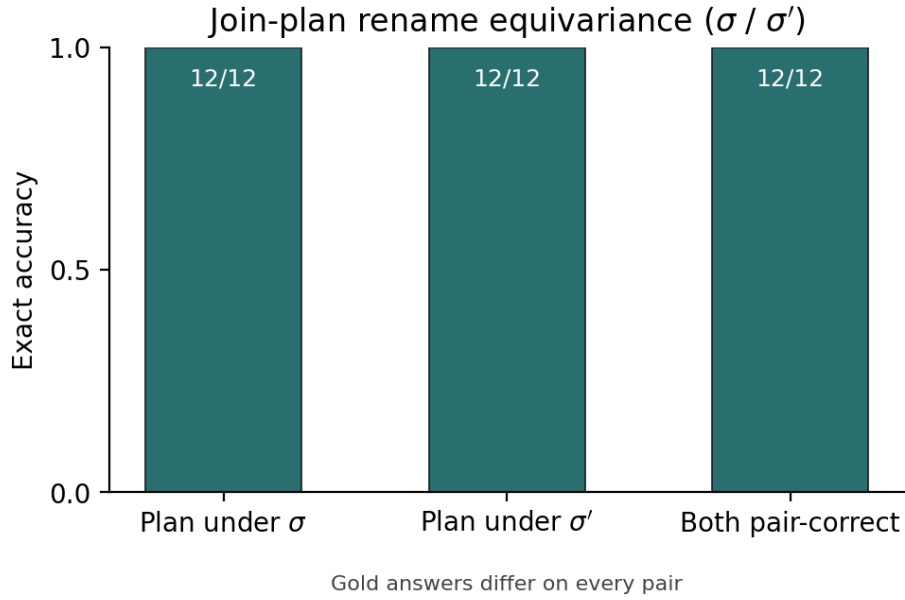


Figure 4: Sealed-plan rename equivariance ($n=12$): plans remain correct under a second key σ' with a different gold on every pair.

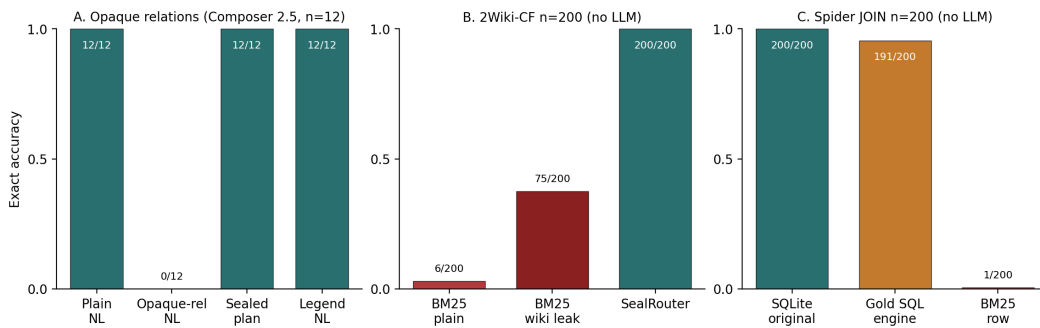


Figure 5: Non-LLM and packaging controls. Panel A is Composer $n=12$; panels B–C are frozen $n=200$ baselines. Left: opaque-rel NL 0/12 vs. plan/legend 12/12 (Composer 2.5, $n=12$). Middle: 2Wiki-CF BM25 6/200, Wikipedia-string leak 75/200, SealRouter 200/200. Right: Spider sqlite 200/200, gold-SQL engine 191/200, BM25 1/200. CEO/2Wiki opacity $\times$ prompt-form scores are in the surrounding prose.

H Extended scores

MetaQA-style 2-hop templates on the same public movie graph are a question-form control, not an evaluation on the official MetaQA 14K test split. Plaintext is 32/32 for all three families. Condition A (English question over opaque relations) is OpenAI 32/32, Composer 19/32, Grok 15/32. Condition B hashes those verbs except `[start]`: OpenAI 25/32, Composer 27/32, Grok 14/32 (plans 32/32, 31/32, 32/32). That $n=32$ template cell is not MOVIE-B. Packaging cells with $n \leq 16$ are Appendix G, not a second 2×2 .

I Sign-flip of the H5 interaction

Let $d_i = \mathbf{1}[\text{opaque correct}] - \mathbf{1}[\text{English correct}]$ and $c_i = d_i^{\text{two}} - d_i^{\text{unique}}$. Of 32 WIKI-H5 items, 24 have $c_i = -1$, one has $c_i = -2$, 7 have $c_i = 0$; $T = -26$. Under exchangeability of unique-path and two-path opacity effects, $p = 2/2^{25} = 5.96 \times 10^{-8}$. That p coincides numerically with the two-path McNemar p (25 vs. 0; McNemar, 1947); the tests are not the same. Opacity is not a randomized within-item treatment. The body reports Wilson intervals and the paired counts.

J Equality recipe (JSON cell)

Verbatim protocol used in Table 11, *not* in WIKI-H5: “QUESTION and CONTEXT use the same encoding. Identical tokens are the same entity or the same field (equality, not English). START is a QUESTION token that also appears as an id value in CONTEXT. The asked field is a QUESTION token that also appears as a JSON key. Walk CONTEXT by token equality. If more than one reading is possible, UNKNOWN.”

The $n=32$ JSON cells are Table 11. Sample sizes $n \leq 16$ (vault, Excel, FinQA, WTQ, middleware) are packaging probes (Appendix G), not WIKI-H5.

K Symbolic execution controls

SealRouter executes a gold sealed path with no LLM. The gold-SQL engine executes gold Spider SQL locally. Figure 5 summarizes those controls.

NeurIPS Paper Checklist

1. Claims

Question: Do the main claims made in the abstract and introduction accurately reflect the paper’s contributions and scope?

Answer: [\[Yes\]](#)

Justification: The abstract and introduction state a measurement protocol, unique-path sealed traversal, and packaging-sensitive abstention under two competing routes. They restrict the matched 2×2 to OpenAI-shaped Wiki-H5 and do not claim a confidentiality proof or a scored (r_1, r_2) .

Guidelines:

- The answer [\[N/A\]](#) means that the abstract and introduction do not include the claims made in the paper.
- The abstract and/or introduction should clearly state the claims made, including the contributions made in the paper and important assumptions and limitations.
- The claims made should match theoretical and experimental results, and reflect how much the results can be expected to generalize to other settings.
- It is fine to include aspirational goals as motivation as long as it is clear that these goals are not attained by the paper.

2. Limitations

Question: Does the paper discuss the limitations of the work performed by the authors?

Answer: [\[Yes\]](#)

Justification: Section 7 states that Wiki-H5 is OpenAI-shaped, $n=32$ on one template, cyclic decoys, packaging sensitivity, harness mismatch, inferred rather than scored (r_1, r_2) , and controls not evaluated here (forced-choice, short symbols, second seed).

Guidelines:

- The answer [\[N/A\]](#) means that the paper has no limitation while the answer [\[No\]](#) means that the paper has limitations, but those are not discussed in the paper.
- The authors are encouraged to create a separate “Limitations” section in their paper.
- Reviewers are specifically instructed not to penalize honesty concerning limitations.

3. Theory assumptions and proofs

Question: For each theoretical result, does the paper provide the full set of assumptions and a complete (and correct) proof?

Answer: [\[N/A\]](#)

Justification: The paper is a measurement protocol. Section 3 defines selection and traversal maps; it does not state theorems.

Guidelines:

- The answer [\[N/A\]](#) means that the paper does not include theoretical results.

4. Experimental result reproducibility

Question: Does the paper fully disclose all the information needed to reproduce the main experimental results of the paper to the extent that it affects the main claims and/or conclusions of the paper (regardless of whether the code and data are provided or not)?

Answer: [\[Yes\]](#)

Justification: Section 4 and Appendix A give seeds, HMAC width, isolation vs. batch, scoring (exact match; empty completions as UNKNOWN), model endpoints, and which cells are answer-line locks. Quizzes are in `runs/`; locked scores in `results/`.

Guidelines:

- The answer [\[N/A\]](#) means that the paper does not include experiments.
- While NeurIPS does not require releasing code, the conference does require all submissions to provide some reasonable avenue for reproducibility.

5. Open access to data and code

Question: Does the paper provide open access to the data and code, with sufficient instructions to faithfully reproduce the main experimental results, as described in supplemental material?

Answer: [Yes]

Justification: Isolation quizzes, locked JSON, reply trees, and `results/SHA256SUMS` are in the public repository named on the title page. Composer 2.5 and Grok 4.5 used a vendor agent SDK that is not the OpenAI API; Appendix A records that mismatch.

Guidelines:

- The answer [N/A] means that the paper does not include experiments requiring code.
- At submission time, to preserve anonymity, the authors should release anonymized versions (if applicable).

6. Experimental setting/details

Question: Does the paper specify all the training and test details (e.g., data splits, hyperparameters, how they were chosen, type of optimizer) necessary to understand the results?

Answer: [Yes]

Justification: No models are trained. Sampling seed, HMAC keys, n , temperature omission, token budgets, and ARM text are in Section 4 and Appendix A.

Guidelines:

- The answer [N/A] means that the paper does not include experiments.
- The experimental setting should be presented in the core of the paper to a level of detail that is necessary to appreciate the results.

7. Experiment statistical significance

Question: Does the paper report error bars suitably and correctly defined or other appropriate information about the statistical significance of the experiments?

Answer: [Yes]

Justification: Wilson 95% intervals ($z=1.96$) and McNemar exact two-sided complete-case tests are reported for the primary OpenAI 2×2. Appendix A notes that cyclic decoys slightly violate the i.i.d. assumption of the Wilson intervals.

Guidelines:

- The answer [N/A] means that the paper does not include experiments.
- The authors should answer [Yes] if the results are accompanied by error bars, confidence intervals, or statistical significance tests, at least for the experiments that support the main claims of the paper.

8. Experiments compute resources

Question: For each experiment, does the paper provide sufficient information on the computer resources (type of compute workers, memory, time of execution) needed to reproduce the experiments?

Answer: [Yes]

Justification: Appendix A records that no models were trained; OpenAI cells used Chat Completions; Composer/Grok used a hosted agent API; query counts for Wiki-H5 and header×decoy are stated.

Guidelines:

- The answer [N/A] means that the paper does not include experiments.

9. Code of ethics

Question: Does the research conducted in the paper conform, in every respect, with the NeurIPS Code of Ethics <https://neurips.cc/public/EthicsGuidelines>?

Answer: [Yes]

Justification: Instances use licensed public graphs. No human subjects, no crowdwork, and no release of model generations as a corpus. HMAC is not treated as a privacy mechanism (Ethical considerations).

Guidelines:

- The answer [N/A] means that the authors have not reviewed the NeurIPS Code of Ethics.

10. **Broader impacts**

Question: Does the paper discuss both potential positive societal impacts and negative societal impacts of the work performed?

Answer: [Yes]

Justification: Ethical considerations states the diagnostic use and the misuse of reading HMAC seals as confidentiality. The protocol is not a deployed anonymizer.

Guidelines:

- The answer [N/A] means that there is no societal impact of the work performed.

11. **Safeguards**

Question: Does the paper describe safeguards that have been put in place for responsible release of data or models that have a high risk for misuse (e.g., pre-trained language models, image generators, or scraped datasets)?

Answer: [N/A]

Justification: The release is quizzes, scores, and hashing code over public KG slices. We do not release pretrained generators or scraped image/text corpora.

Guidelines:

- The answer [N/A] means that the paper poses no such risks.

12. **Licenses for existing assets**

Question: Are the creators or original owners of assets (e.g., code, data, models), used in the paper, properly credited and are the license and terms of use explicitly mentioned and properly respected?

Answer: [Yes]

Justification: Wikidata CEO records (CC0), WikiMovies/MetaQA as publicly released, 2WikiMultihopQA (Apache-2.0), and Spider (CC-BY-SA-4.0) are cited with licenses in Ethical considerations.

Guidelines:

- The answer [N/A] means that the paper does not use existing assets.
- The name of the license (e.g., CC-BY 4.0) should be included for each asset.

13. **New assets**

Question: Are new assets introduced in the paper well documented and is the documentation provided alongside the assets?

Answer: [Yes]

Justification: Isolation quizzes, locked scores, and SHA-256 pins are documented in Appendix A and the repository README. Model generations are not released as a corpus.

Guidelines:

- The answer [N/A] means that the paper does not release new assets.
- At submission time, remember to anonymize your assets (if applicable).

14. **Crowdsourcing and research with human subjects**

Question: For crowdsourcing experiments and research with human subjects, does the paper include the full text of instructions given to participants and screenshots, if applicable, as well as details about compensation (if any)?

Answer: [N/A]

Justification: The study evaluates language-model APIs on public graphs. There are no human participants.

Guidelines:

- The answer [N/A] means that the paper does not involve crowdsourcing nor research with human subjects.

15. Institutional review board (IRB) approvals or equivalent for research with human subjects

Question: Does the paper describe potential risks incurred by study participants, whether such risks were disclosed to the subjects, and whether Institutional Review Board (IRB) approvals (or an equivalent approval/review based on the requirements of your country or institution) were obtained?

Answer: [N/A]

Justification: No human-subjects research.

Guidelines:

- The answer [N/A] means that the paper does not involve crowdsourcing nor research with human subjects.

16. Declaration of LLM usage

Question: Does the paper describe the usage of LLMs if it is an important, original, or non-standard component of the core methods in this research? Note that if the LLM is used only for writing, editing, or formatting purposes and does not impact the core methodology, scientific rigor, or originality of the research, declaration is not required.

Answer: [N/A]

Justification: HMAC sealing and the quiz files are the method. Language models are evaluated systems (Section 4), not a component of the protocol.

Guidelines:

- The answer [N/A] means that the core method development in this research does not involve LLMs as any important, original, or non-standard components.